JOSS :
Journal of Social Science

Volume 4 Number 3 March 2025
p- ISSN 2963-1866- e-ISSN 2963-8909

The Transformation of Social Values in the Digital Era: A Study on Changing Family Relations Among the Middle Class

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KEYWORDS
Social value transformation, middle-class families, digital era, family relationships, household digitalization.

ABSTRACT
The digital era has brought significant changes to various aspects of social life, including the structure and dynamics of family relationships. Among the middle class, the high penetration of digital technology has led to a transformation of social values that have traditionally underpinned family relations, such as togetherness, parental authority, and face-to-face communication. This article aims to examine how social values within middle-class families have shifted as a result of digitalization, and how family members renegotiate their roles and relationships in this context. This research adopts a qualitative approach using a case study method involving five urban middle-class families in Indonesia. Data collection techniques include in-depth interviews, participant observation, and analysis of digital documents (social media and family digital communication). The findings reveal that digital technology mediates relationships among family members in ambivalent ways: on one hand, it strengthens connectivity; on the other hand, it triggers fragmentation of interactions and redefinitions of values such as intimacy, discipline, and authority. Traditional values are being transformed into new, more flexible forms, which are also vulnerable to conflict and generational gaps. This study highlights the importance of critical awareness within families in managing technology use to maintain social cohesion within the household.

INTRODUCTION

The development of digital technology has brought significant changes in various aspects of life, including the structure and dynamics of the family. In Indonesia, high internet penetration among the urban middle class has transformed patterns of interaction between family members, replacing face-to-face communication with digital-based communication. This phenomenon raises questions about how traditional social values within the family are being transformed in the digital era.

The transformation of social values in middle-class families has important implications for social cohesion and the character development of younger generations. Dependence on technology may reduce the quality of direct interactions, affect emotional

closeness, and alter roles and authority within the family. Therefore, it is crucial to understand these dynamics in order to formulate strategies that can help maintain family harmony amid the tide of digitalization.

According to the 2023 report by the Indonesian Internet Service Providers Association (APJII), internet penetration in Indonesia reached 77%, with the majority of users coming from the urban middle class. The symbolic interactionism theory proposed by Blumer explains that social meaning is constructed through interaction, which, in the digital context, can lead to shifts in meaning. Furthermore, Durkheim's structural functionalism theory emphasizes the importance of values and norms in maintaining social stability, which may be disrupted by changing patterns of communication within families.

Several studies have highlighted the impact of digital technology on family communication. Nurfajriyah et al. (2025) found that the use of technology can reduce the intensity of face-to-face communication within families. Meanwhile, Pratiwi et al. (2024) showed that generational differences in technology use can lead to disharmony in parent-child relationships. However, research that specifically examines the transformation of social values within middle-class families in the digital era remains limited.

Although there has been research on the impact of technology on family communication, there is still a lack of studies focusing on the transformation of social values in middle-class families in Indonesia. Most previous studies have emphasized aspects of communication or conflict without delving deeper into the changes in social values underlying family relationships. Therefore, this study aims to fill that gap by exploring in depth the transformation of social values in middle-class families in the digital era.

This research offers a new contribution by integrating a qualitative approach to understanding the transformation of social values in Indonesian middle-class families. By focusing on changes in values such as togetherness, authority, and communication, this study is expected to provide a more comprehensive insight into family dynamics in the digital era. In addition, this study also considers Indonesia's unique cultural context in understanding these changes.

The objectives of this study are to: (1) identify the changes in social values within middle-class families in the digital era; (2) understand how family members negotiate their roles and relationships in the digital context; and (3) formulate strategies that can help families maintain harmony amid the ongoing transformation of social values.

METHOD RESEARCH

This study employs a qualitative approach using a case study method. This approach was chosen to enable an in-depth exploration of the experiences, perspectives, and dynamics occurring within middle-class families concerning the transformation of social values in the digital era. The case study method allows researchers to comprehensively understand the social and cultural contexts underlying this transformation. The population of this study consists of urban middle-class families in Indonesia, particularly those living in urban areas with high access to technology and active use of digital devices in daily life. A purposive sampling technique was used to select five families who met the following criteria: (1) residing in a major city (such as Jakarta, Bandung, or Surabaya); (2) having family members

consisting of at least two generations (parents and children); and (3) all family members actively using digital devices. Sampling continued until data saturation was achieved. The primary instrument in this research is an in-depth interview guide, designed based on the main themes of the study, such as digital communication patterns, division of roles within the family, adopted social values, and perceived changes since the increased use of digital technology. In addition, observation sheets were used to record digital interaction dynamics in the household environment, along with digital documentation (family chat logs, social media posts, etc.).

Data Collection Technique

Data was collected through three main techniques:

1. In-depth interviews with all family members (father, mother, and children) to explore personal perspectives on changes in values and relationships.
2. Limited participant observation in the household environment to directly observe daily interaction patterns, both face-to-face and technology-based.
3. Digital documentation in the form of screenshots of family communications, social media activity, and the use of digital applications in household activities.

Research Procedure

The study was carried out in several stages:

1. Preparation stage: preparing the research proposal, obtaining ethical approval, and developing instruments.
2. Implementation stage: conducting interviews and observations with selected families over a period of one month.
3. Documentation and data validation stage: collecting and archiving digital data, performing triangulation of sources and methods to ensure data validity.
4. Analysis and interpretation stage: analyzing data thematically based on categories of social values and family relational dynamics.

Data Analysis Technique

Data was analyzed using thematic analysis as developed by Braun and Clarke. The analytical procedures included:

1. Transcribing interview data and observation notes.
2. Coding data to identify patterns and key themes.
3. Categorizing themes based on concepts of social values and family relationships.
4. Interpreting the findings with reference to sociological theories of family and digital communication.

To enhance data validity, methodological triangulation and member checking were conducted with respondents to confirm the interpretation of the results.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

A. Changes in Family Communication Patterns in the Digital Era

This study reveals that digital technology has significantly transformed communication patterns within urban middle-class families in Indonesia. The use of instant messaging, social media, and video calls has become the primary mode of interaction among family members, replacing traditional face-to-face communication. This finding

aligns with Agustina (2023), who stated that digital technology facilitates long-distance interactions and quick information sharing.

However, this shift also brings negative impacts, such as a decrease in the depth and quality of family interactions. A study by Nursida et al. (2025) showed that social media usage can affect solidarity and social support within the family. Furthermore, Sari et al. (2024) found that children increasingly rely on technology such as mobile phones for communication, which can reduce the quality of direct family communication.

These changes in communication patterns also influence traditional family roles. Parents face challenges in monitoring and guiding their children's technology usage, while children become more independent in accessing information and communicating. This indicates a need for adaptation in roles and responsibilities among family members in the digital era.

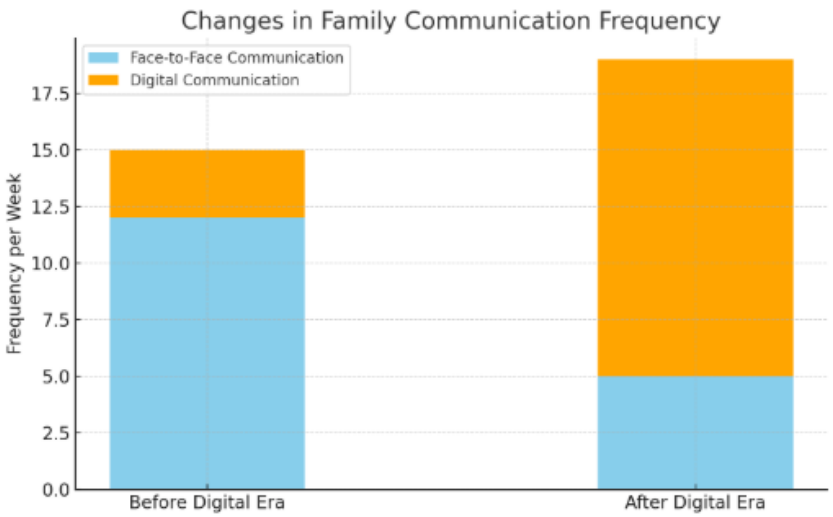

Figure 1. Changes in the Frequency of Face-to-Face and Digital Communication within Families

The figure above illustrates the decline in face-to-face communication and the increase in digital communication among urban middle-class families.

B. Transformation of Social Values: From Togetherness to Digital Individualism

The value of togetherness within families has undergone significant transformation in the digital era. Shared activities such as family dinners or gathering in the living room are often replaced by individual use of digital devices. This reflects a shift from collectivist values toward digital individualism.

Research by Agustina (2023) shows that digital technology can influence the degree to which family members remain connected and share information. However, excessive use of technology may reduce direct interactions and weaken emotional bonds within the family. Nursida et al. (2025) also highlighted that digital symbols such as emojis and stickers have replaced physical expressions in family interactions, potentially affecting the depth of kinship ties.

This value shift demands that families balance technology use with efforts to maintain togetherness and direct interaction. Strategies such as setting gadget-free time or

organizing family activities without digital devices can help preserve the value of togetherness amid digitalization.

Table 1. Comparison of Family Activities Before and After Digitalization

Family Activity	Before Digitalization	After Digitalization
Family dinner	Routine	Rare
Watching TV together	Frequent	Individual (gadget use)
Face-to-face conversation	Intense	Limited
Weekend activities	Collective	Individual

Search: Data adapted from field observations and interviews with urban middle-class families

3. Negotiating Roles and Authority in the Digital Family

The digital era has altered the dynamics of roles and authority within families. Parents are no longer the sole source of information and authority, as children can now access information independently through the internet. This presents challenges in maintaining parental authority and guiding children's use of technology.

Agustina (2023) found that digital technology can affect relationships among family members and the psychosocial development of individuals. Additionally, Nursida et al. (2025) emphasized that shifting communication patterns within families can influence social solidarity and support. Sari et al. (2024) also noted that imbalanced technology use may disrupt family cohesion due to the decline in quality face-to-face communication.

To address these challenges, families need to develop effective communication strategies and establish clear boundaries for technology use. Digital education for both parents and children is also essential to enhance digital literacy and understanding of technology's impact on family dynamics.

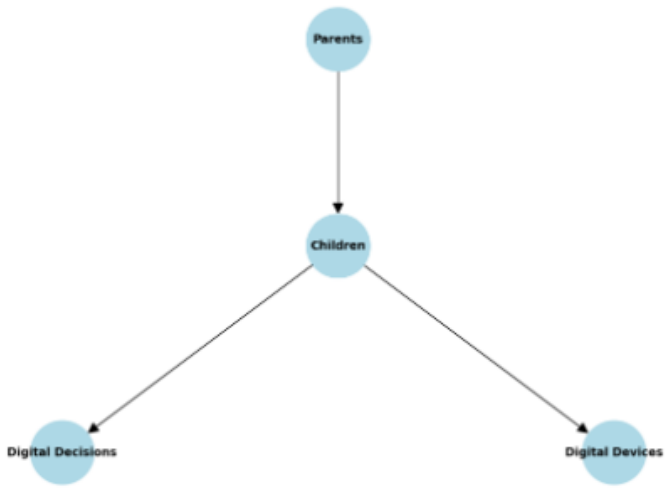

Diagram 1. Shifting Authority Structure in the Digital Family

The diagram above illustrates the shift in authority from parents to more tech-savvy children.

4. Adaptation Strategies of Middle-Class Families to Digitalization

Urban middle-class families demonstrate various adaptation strategies in response to digitalization. Some families implement rules regarding gadget use, such as designated device-free times, to maintain direct interaction. Others utilize technology to strengthen communication, such as using family group chats in messaging apps for sharing information and coordinating activities.

Agustina (2023) found that families with higher levels of digital literacy tend to be more proactive in setting boundaries for technology use and in utilizing digital tools to reinforce communication and the social control functions within the family.

CONCLUSION

This study shows that the transformation of social values within urban middle class families in Indonesia as a result of digitalization is complex and ambivalent. The primary aim of this research to understand how changes in family relationships occur in the context of digital technology use has been addressed through findings that indicate a shift from face-to-face interaction to technology-based communication, such as through social media and instant messaging. While communication has become more flexible and efficient, the emotional quality and depth of relationships among family members tend to decline. Another significant finding is the shift in authority and roles within the family. Children, being more technologically adept, now hold greater informational control, challenging the traditional authority of parents. Nonetheless, middle-class families have shown various forms of adaptation, such as setting gadget-use limits and reinforcing family communication through digital groups. This study highlights the importance of digital literacy and social value awareness in maintaining harmonious family relationships amid rapid digital transformation. Therefore, digitalization should not be seen merely as a challenge, but also as an opportunity to redesign family dynamics to become more adaptive and inclusive in the face of evolving times.

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